

Chapter 141-3

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After Liang Shi went downstairs to find Liang Wanwan, she spotted two people she disliked at the same time she caught sight of Liang Wanwan.

—Qiu Zimin and Liang Xinran.

Qiu Zimin was wearing a white long dress that didn't quite match her temperament, looking rather out of place. Meanwhile, Liang Xinran wore a light blue dress with a pair of silver high heels, actually looking like she had the air of a wealthy young lady.

Liang Wanwan stood across from them with her head lowered, as if she were being scolded.

Liang Shi originally didn't want to go over, but standing on the stairs and watching Liang Wanwan like that, she ultimately went downstairs and called out from not far away: "Wanwan."

Liang Wanwan raised her head, bit her lip, looking somewhat troubled.

Qiu Zimin and Liang Xinran heard the voice and turned around in unison. Liang Shi met their gazes expressionlessly.

"Wanwan, let's go." Liang Shi said.

Liang Wanwan was about to lift her foot when she heard Qiu Zimin say sharply: "Don't you dare."

Liang Wanwan's footsteps retreated again, but her face showed difficulty as she said in a low voice: "Mom, I have something to do, I need to leave first."

"Liang Wanwan." Qiu Zimin also remembered that family scandals shouldn't be aired in public. "Usually when I ask you to come home, you always make excuses about having things to do at school, yet you can accompany someone else to an art exhibition? Are you doing this on purpose? Do you want to make me so angry I die, just like your eldest and second brother?"

"Didn't eldest brother already go back to the company..." Liang Wanwan didn't dare to resist Qiu Zimin much, but she still weakly argued back: "Second brother went back too. How could they be trying to make you..."

"Liang Wanwan!" Qiu Zimin called her name sternly, with a warning tone.

Liang Wanwan immediately fell silent, even trembling with fright.

Watching from not far away, Liang Shi's brows furrowed tightly. Just then, Chen Mian walked over and lightly patted her shoulder: "What's going on?"

"Help me out." Liang Shi grabbed Chen Mian: "Go bring my younger sister over here."

"That one?" Chen Mian tilted her chin toward Liang Wanwan's direction.

"Yes."

"Why don't you go yourself?" Chen Mian asked.

Liang Shi: "...There are reasons I can't speak of."

Chen Mian didn't ask further. Liang Shi said: "I'll treat you to a meal."

Chen Mian raised an eyebrow: "Do I need you to buy me a meal?"

After saying that, she answered herself: "Actually, I haven't figured out where to have lunch yet."

In reality, the organizers here were having a group meal, but Chen Mian didn't want to attend. Such occasions of social pleasantries weren't suited for her.

Chen Mian raised her hand and took off her glasses, revealing those eyes that carried a few degrees of sharpness—utterly indifferent.

She lifted her foot and walked toward Liang Wanwan.

When Liang Wanwan noticed that Chen Mian was coming, her head lowered even more.

She absolutely didn't want Chen Mian to see her looking so pathetic.

But things didn't go as she wished—not only did Chen Mian see her, she was walking right toward her.

Liang Wanwan's hands clenched into fists, her whole body trembling.

Qiu Zimin questioned her with furrowed brows: "Liang Wanwan, do you also want to never come home again, just like your two brothers?"

Liang Wanwan's voice was as faint as a mosquito: "No..."

Liang Xinran said from the side: "Mom, don't be angry. Wanwan is still young, and there's so much going on at school. It's normal not to come home. A girl her age has so much freedom in university."

"Yes, so much freedom at school." Qiu Zimin became even angrier upon hearing this. "So there's no freedom at home, is that it? You're all just following your brothers' example. I can understand your eldest brother protecting that person, but what about you two? You and your second brother are just fence-sitters.¹ Liang Wanwan, have I ever stopped you from doing things at school? But count for yourself—how long has it been since you've come home?"

Liang Wanwan bit her lower lip and said in a low voice: "Mom, please stop talking."

There was a hint of pleading in her tone.

But Qiu Zimin only heard her mosquito-like voice; she didn't catch a single word of what was said.

Qiu Zimin poked her in frustration,² "Is this what I usually teach you? You can't even speak properly anymore? Go ahead and learn from her then—see what you can learn..."

As she spoke, she was about to poke Liang Wanwan's forehead again, but her finger was stopped by someone.

Chen Mian was wearing a loose white dress shirt, with one side tucked into her black dress pants.

Since today was a somewhat important occasion, she had even put on a tie under her white shirt—though like her shirt, it hung loosely.

She was a bit taller than Liang Wanwan, directly blocking Liang Wanwan from the side.

Qiu Zimin had her finger grabbed. She looked up to see someone she didn't recognize, and after a moment of stunned silence, she said coldly: "Who are you?"

"Her friend." Chen Mian said: "In public like this, Auntie, isn't this a bit inappropriate?"

Qiu Zimin frowned and let out a light breath. She didn't want to embarrass herself in public either, but the other person was standing there, using considerable force to bend her finger back—it hurt quite a bit.

It took a great deal of effort to finally pull her finger free. Qiu Zimin shook her finger out. "I'm disciplining my daughter. Even if you're Wanwan's friend, you should know your place."

"Huh?" Chen Mian's genuine astonishment carried a hint of contempt, making it rather uncomfortable to hear.

Qiu Zimin said: "What do you mean by that?"

Chen Mian shrugged. "Nothing really. If you think a friend stopping you from doing this is not knowing her place, then how about girlfriend."

Chen Mian met her gaze, looking extremely arrogant.

Chen Mian curved her lips into a light smile. "I can't stand watching others bully my girlfriend. Your daughter is all grown up now, old enough to have a girlfriend, yet you're still acting like this in public—do you even know how to raise a daughter? I'm glad my girlfriend isn't like you, otherwise I wouldn't dare have children in the future."

Qiu Zimin: "...?"

Chen Mian's words were full of twists and turns, cursing Qiu Zimin in a roundabout way.

Without a single dirty word.

It took Qiu Zimin a while to react. "You..."

But before she could retort and curse back, Chen Mian had already grabbed Liang Wanwan's wrist and walked away from her, swagger and all.

This infuriated Qiu Zimin to no end.

And in that instant, Liang Wanwan, whose wrist was being held by Chen Mian, raised her head to look at her back.

Chen Mian had a slight hunch, not the perfectly straight kind.

But she was tall enough that it didn't affect her posture at all.

Liang Wanwan's palms were damp with sweat as she looked at Chen Mian's back through the misty fog in her eyes.

Footnotes:

¹ **Fence-sitters** (牆頭草): Literally "grass on top of a wall," this is a Chinese idiom describing someone who sways whichever way the wind blows—someone who doesn't take sides or changes their stance based on the situation. Here, Qiu Zimin is accusing Liang Wanwan and her second brother of not being loyal to her.

² **Poked her in frustration** (恨鐵不成鋼地戳了她一下): The phrase "恨鐵不成鋼" literally means "hating iron for not becoming steel." It's an idiom describing the frustration one feels when someone fails to meet expectations or live up to their potential—like being disappointed that iron won't turn into something more valuable like steel. It conveys a mix of anger and disappointment, typically from a parent or mentor toward someone they care about.